Jeffrey's Moatmeal Accident

By

INTRODUCTION

Have you ever attempted to do something nice for someone and then ended up hurting them instead? It kind of discourages you from future acts of kindness. They say "no good deed goes unpunished." Well, that statement has never been truer than in "Jeffrey's Moatmeal Accident" by Jordan Sonnenblick.

If I live to be a hundred and seventy-nine, I will never forget October 7th of this year. Oh, I'll try. I've been trying already. But I will never be able to throw off the weight of this particular day.

The weird thing is, the day started off great. I recall that I woke up early, for some reason, and couldn't go back to sleep. So I got out of bed, tiptoed to the bathroom, peed, and did my usual slow-motion Ninja walk to get down our squeaky stairs without waking up the 'rents or Jeffrey. I stopped in the kitchen to suck

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down some OJ, and then continued my silent journey to the basement. My dad has a separate little office down there. He's an accountant, and because he sometimes works really late hours during tax season, he had the walls filled with extra insulation for warmth and soundproofing. I figured I'd get some practice in on the pad before school, so I set myself up in the office. I started to work my way through my usual warm-up routine - five minutes of single-stroke rolls (right-left-right-left), five minutes of double-stroke rolls (right-right-left-left), and five minutes of paradiddles (right-left-right-right, left-right-left-left). My hands were feeling particularly loose, and somehow it was nice being up before anyone else, doing my own thing. Which, of course, meant that Jeffrey was bound to find me.

Steven!

AHHH! You almost gave me a heart attack you little madman!

(This made him giggle hysterically, as it always does when I pretend he's snuck up on me. But today he

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really HAD snuck up on me; my drumming concentration can be pretty fierce).

Steven, I don't feel good.

Lately, Jeffrey had been complaining a lot that his "parts hurt," which we hadn't been understanding too well. I thought it was just another one of his little-kid things, like the summer he turned three, when he convinced himself that he slept with his eyes open. I spent weeks trying to convince him that he slept with his eyes closed, just like everyone else on the planet. I finally videotaped about fifteen minutes of him sleeping, which I thought would settle the issue. When I played the tape back for him, though, he insisted: "Of course my eyes close SOMETIMES when I sleep. That's just what we call a 'slow blink.'" So you can see why nobody was running outside to flag down an ambulance when this kid's "parts hurt."

What do you want me to do?

Can you make me some moatmeal?

Some oatmeal?

Right, some moatmeal.

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Jeffery, give me a break. I'm practicing here.

But I'm cold. I need moatmeal to warm up my parts.

I could see I wasn't going to get out of this one without a fight, and I am a pretty big oatmeal fan myself to tell you the truth. However, I couldn't resist teasing Jeffrey a little, so I said:

Cream of wheat?

Moatmeal.

Cream of wheat?

MOATMEAL.

Cream of wheat?

MOATMEAL!!!

Okay, you don't have to call out the Nazi Guard I'll make you the oatmeal!

Yay! Moatmeal!

Up in the kitchen, I sat Jeffrey on a bar stool so he could "help" by mixing the oatmeal with the water before I nuked it. My mom always tells me not to leave Jeffrey up on the high stools without me standing right next to him, but she's ridiculously overprotective. If she had her way, he'd be wearing body armor to

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kindergarten. Anyway, he was babbling away about how our "special moatmeal treat" would "re-fix" his "parts," when I turned away for a second to get a wooden spoon. I heard a swish, a crack, a thump, and a little whimper. When I looked back, I realized that Jeffrey must have slipped off of the stool and banged his face on the counter. He looked up at me from the floor for that miserable split-second little kids always take before the wailing starts, and I saw a drop of blood under his nose. Then two things happened at once: he started to scream like a banshee, and the drop of blood turned into a torrent.

I grabbed the hand towel off of the refrigerator handle and held it to Jeffrey's nose. He looked terrified in a way I hadn't seen before, and he was still screaming. I found myself pulling him onto my lap, saying things to him over and over, like:

Hush, Jeffy- I never call him that unless he's upset-*it'll be alright.*

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When this didn't stop his wailing, and I knew the 'rents were about to come flying into the room any minute, I started to get a bit impatient:

C'mon, Jeffrey! It's a little nosebleed. You've had a million nosebleeds before, right?

No, I've had TWO nosebleeds. The one time when you let me ride the skateboard and--

Okay, two nosebleeds. But nosebleeds go away, Jeffy. You're fine. Now stop shouting before Mom and Dad Steven! What have you done to your brother?

Doh! Too late. . .

Nothing, Mom. I was making him breakfast and he fell off his stool.

He just fell off? There was no pushing?

No.

No shoving, Steven?

No.

Did you drop him, Steven?

No.

Was this one of your wrestling moves, Jeffrey?

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Finally, my parents were getting past the interrogation phase, and dealing with the injured child - who, by the way, was still receiving first aid from his heroic, wronged brother.

NO, Mommy.

Did you really JUST fall, Jeffrey?

Why does everybody in my family talk in these dramatic CAPITAL LETTERS all the time? Why am I the only calm one?

You know what, Mom? I body-slammed him, OK? 1 decided it would be really fun to let a five-year-old on a bar stool at 6:42 a.m., take a running leap, and knock him down like we were trying out for the WWF. It worked great, too.

Son, don't be defensive with your mother!

Defensive, Dad? DEFENSIVE?

Now they had me sinking to their capital-letter level. *YES! Defensive!*

And FRESH!

Thanks for chiming in, Mom. This could have gone on for months or even years, in

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an unending round of guilt-trip Ping-Pong, except Jeffrey stopped us all in our tracks:

Mommy, it hurts.

This came out muffled, and we must have looked confused. So Jeffrey pushed my hand with the towel out of the way. It was another one of these frozen moments that always seem to happen to me; we all just looked at the towel. and Jeffrey's nose, and the front of my pajama shirt. There was an unbelievable amount of blood!

Oh God, Jeffy.

Oh, my God.

Get my shoes, Steven. I'm taking your brother to the emergency room.

I'd never seen my mom take one of our injuries so seriously before.

Honey, do you want us to go with?

Ahem, Dad.

No, you take this, one to school.

Great-for the crime of attempted breakfast-making, I got demoted from "beloved first-born" to "this one." So my Mom grabbed Jeffrey off of my lap,

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put another towel to his face (this one with ice wrapped in it), somehow got her shoes, his winter coat, her jacket, keys, her cell phone, and her purse, and got almost to the front door, before Jeffrey had time to say:

Blankie!

Go get your brother's blanket, Steven!

For once I went to get my brother something without saying a word about it. When I gave it to him, and my mom opened the door, I got one last long look at his frightened face over my mom's shoulder. As she started down the driveway toward the car, I had this weird feeling that my brother was getting smaller and smaller. My dad closed the door, and told me to go get ready for school.

Dad, is he…?

I'm sure he'll be fine, Steven. Now it's time to go!

That's when I looked at the kitchen clock, and saw that it was already 7:09. We had to be out the door in eleven minutes, so I went upstairs, tossed the bloody PJ shirt in the bathroom sink, took the world's fastest

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shower, combed my hair into some kind of shape, and hurled myself into jeans and a Sum 41 T-shirt. By 7: 14 I was at the door,

Dad! I'm ready!

My dad appeared with the attaché case I'd bought him for Christmas two years ago.

Dad, are you, OK?

I never particularly noticed my dad's moods, but he was looking kind of pale and tense. I glanced over at the kitchen, and noticed that he had cleaned up Jeffrey's blood from the floor, which couldn't have been fun.

Fine. Ready.,

Great! And now for a fun ride to school with Caveman Dad. In the car, things were 1000 % silent until I couldn't stand it anymore. I put on the radio to WZZO, the rock station, and started playing drums on my legs along with the Rush song that was on, My dad reached out and turned off the radio, which was very unusual for him, Even though my mom has always been my big "drum fan," my dad had at least succeeded in

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tuning out my tapping (OK. he called it "pounding" and my teachers always referred to it as "banging") on hundreds of car rides before this one.

Sorry, Steve. He said this with a weak little "I'm sorry" smile. *I need to concentrate on the road right now.*

Another few minutes of that weird "we're ignoring a topic" silence brought us to my school. Before I got out of the car, I turned toward my dad for one more bit of whatever comfort he could give:

Dad, is he. . .

I told you Steven. No he just bleeds a lot. No, It's . . .

just , , , bleed a lot. Now get going!

When I got to my locker, Renee Albert said "Hi" to me from about a foot away - her locker has always been next to mine-and I realized I hadn't brushed my teeth.

Perfect.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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